

THE LONELINESS OF SONIA AND SUNNY
By Kiran Desai
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₹999;
688 pages

story," says Desai. "I wrote the stories of all the different characters separately, and then tried to see where their stories would intersect."

The novel begins in 1996, when Sonia is a lonely college student in Vermont, and Sunny is starting out as a journalist in New York. The pair is first introduced through their families—Sunny's mother forwards him the marriage proposal by post—before their actual meet-cute on an overnight train. They first exchange words only a third of the way through the book, and from that point on they weave in and out of each other's lives. At nearly 700 pages, it's a fabulous, immersive read, richly plotted and populated. "I wanted to write a book like the books I love, like *Middlemarch*, or [the books of] Tolstoy or Hilary Mantel," says Desai. "I thought, 'Let me write my big fat book now'."

The big, fat book boasts an eclectic, memorable cast of family, friends and frenemies. There's Sunny's mother, Babita Bhatia, a wealthy widow with myriad domestic troubles and one eye on how to lure away a fantastic kebab cook; Mina Foi, Sonia's sidelined maiden aunt; and Satya, Sunny's best friend, a young immigrant doctor burdened in his search for a wife. "When I read love stories that are set in the US or Europe, the absence of family shocks me," says Desai. "And I wonder how the author can write a story where it's just two people and very little or no presence of a cast of family members. It strikes me as very hard to do in an Indian story."

Despite the presence of large and boisterous families, loneliness is threaded through the novel—whether in marriage, widowhood, or life abroad. "It is true that as an immigrant, you do, in some ways, make an unknowable creature of yourself," says Desai. "As Sunny says, he doesn't know where his thinking is coming from, he doesn't even trust his own emotions."

Desai left India in her teens. "The diaspora is a wonderful place to write from, but it took me a while to understand that," she says. "I was very worried about losing India in terms of writing landscape... and there's a depth of knowledge that I will never have over here."

The novel makes sly references to diaspora writing of a pandering kind; the eye-catching journalistic profile of the man with the long fingernails, fiction about arranged marriages and boys who turn into monkeys. "Don't write Orientalist nonsense! Don't cheapen your country...," one character says.

Desai is clearly having fun, whether sending up clichéd writing, satirising the elite or dabbling in miniature domestic comedies. "How can you not find the world so ludicrous?" she asks. "We are dealing with completely ridiculous situations every day." ■

—Bhavya Dore

***Cloud Atlas*. Like those books, *The Pretenders* has characters scattered across the globe, connected by the deadly Delta wave of the Covid pandemic that began in April 2021.**

Shamsher Singh ('Sammy'), leading a comfortable life in Delhi, sees the equilibrium in his existence being disturbed in real time, thanks to past traumas being dredged up. His childhood friend lives next door to Sammy and her son Farid is negotiating the vagaries of a long-distance relationship with the 20-something Beijing surfer Mei. In Bangkok, Changez's life turns on a pin after he is rescued from a xenophobic assault by a kindly woman. And in Jakarta, Mei's mother Nina has to contend with the reality that her husband's paranoid tendencies are becoming a threat to those around him.

At one point, Singh writes, "If there can be an advantage to a pandemic, it would be that things you would never have noticed otherwise are revealed." This describes the novel in a nutshell: Singh uses the isolation necessitated by the Delta wave as a versatile plot device, showing us the inside of these characters' homes, as well as the innermost corners of their minds. His previous novel *Into the Forest* featured a kind of convergence caused by Covid—people from around the globe converging upon a nameless German town, their lives growing more and more intertwined, cornered women finding a common purpose and so on. Conversely, *The Pretenders* represents a divergence of sorts—mothers and sons growing apart, lovers second-guessing each other's motivations and so on. Like the best novels, it has both a propulsive story and a distinctive voice, and you finish the third act wanting to stay with these characters for longer. ■

SINGH USES THE ISOLATION DUE TO THE PANDEMIC AS A PLOT DEVICE, SHOWING THE CORNERS OF CHARACTERS' MINDS

—Aditya Mani Jha